

Studies in Ammianus Marcellinus: II: Ammianus' Knowledge and Use of Greek and Latin Literature
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STUDIES IN AMMIANUS MARCELLINUS

II: Ammianus' Knowledge and Use of Greek and Latin Literature

The extent and degree of Ammianus' knowledge of Greek and Latin literature are intrinsically important questions[1]. Apart from any direct connection between his own learning and the history he wrote, we should like to know the literary contents of a mind in the body of a fourth century *domesticus protector* whose experiences and ambitions led him in later life to write a history of his times. Unfortunately, the general considerations usually applicable to a Greek intellectual would here mislead us, even if the assumption were sound that he stemmed from Antioch and at some point, soon or late, commenced an association with Libanius and his circle[2]. Ammianus not only undertook military service at a young age, perhaps before he reached twenty[3]; the service he entered was not traditional for a Greek youth but was the special preserve of the new and preeminently barbarian military aristocracy[4]. It will be salutary to remember also that we are ignorant even of the nature of Ammianus' early education[5]. Much depends on the identity of his parents and the profession which he intended to enter. Fortunately, although we can only guess about his parentage[6], it is legitimate to assume from his choice of profession that he was a bilingual Greek, for Ammianus can hardly have contemplated a military career without facility in the official language of the army and the court[7]. But even assuming that his education had primarily been Greek, so that he had read as a boy some Homer, Hesiod, Demosthenes, Lysias, Herodotus and Thucydides[8], the fact remains that his education had been preliminary, truncated by his early dedication to a military career. Am-

[1] The present paper is a revised version of one delivered at the Universities of London, Durham and Manchester in Spring 1987.

[2] See Part I on "The Letter of Libanius and Ammianus' Connection with Antioch", in *Historia* 41 (1992) fasc. 3, pp. 328–344.

[3] We are ignorant of the terminus post quem; for the data see Part I, n. 4.

[4] See Part I, n. 5. For the names of the *protectores* known to have served during Ammianus' tenure of the post, see *PLRE* I, pp. 1122–1123.

[5] That he was educated in Antioch in "liberal studies," i. e., rhetoric, is a misconception arising from an unnecessary interpretation of 18. 6. 20. See Part I, n. 4.

[6] J. Gimazane, *Ammien Marcellin, sa vie et son oeuvre* (Thèse Toulouse 1889) 25 f., tentatively identified his father with that Marcellinus who served as *Comes Orientis* (*PLRE* I no. 7); that he was the offspring of a successful and influential soldier is intrinsically likely.

[7] On the importance of Latin to the pursuit of a career in the imperial service, see J. Matthews, *The Roman Empire of Ammianus* (London 1989) 71.

[8] This is the list given by Libanius *Ep.* 1036 Foerster. Julian, *Ep.* 61 c 423 A Bidez, adds Isocrates.

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mianus was *domesticus protector* at a stage in life when Themistius, Libanius, Eunapius – truly learned men of the time – were solidifying their knowledge of the classics. We cannot, therefore, automatically regard Ammianus as if he were an ordinary Greek of the upper class, who enjoyed a standard and leisurely Hellenic education. His Greek scholarship (like his Latin) needs to be authenticated by the evidence of his history, particularly since his adoption of Latin as the language of this work inevitably suggests that his learning and capabilities inclined in that direction. Modern scholars, it is true, follow a different set of presuppositions. Many infer substantial learning on the Greek side and, at a later stage in Ammianus' life, the hasty and imperfect assimilation of literary Latin[9]. The question is whether the material evidence supports this view.

Since general impressions can often victimize us, and Ammianus' history seems replete with enormous learning in both languages, it is important to state at once that it is a habit of Ammianus to present an array of ancient authorities, Greek and Latin, *without having consulted them directly*[10]. One typical example of his technique of citation occurs in 26. 9. 11, where the information is given that, according to Lucilius and Cicero, Crassus (see, for him, Pliny, *NH* 7,79) laughed but once in his life: *quem in vita semel risisse Lucilius affirmat et Tullius.* Cicero (De fin. 5. 30, 92) was Ammianus' (single) source, for it was Cicero, in fact, who cited Lucilius as his own authority: *quem semel ait in vita risisse Lucilius.* Clearly, Ammianus was interested in the constellation of celebrated names he could associate with a piece of information; apparently, he wished his work to resonate with the great names of the past, perhaps to give a sense of their continuing life and relevance as well as to dignify his narrative. In any case, neither the citation of a name nor, by logical extension, the citation of information linked with a name, can by itself establish Ammianus' utilization of the original source.

Even so, reliable indications, if not of the sum of Ammianus' knowledge, at least of its most important constituent parts, pervade the history. On the negative side (to anticipate the argument), Ammianus displays very little active memory of the best Greek writers. That he had once read them or that he read them more than once need neither be affirmed nor denied. The essential point is that, unlike the typical Greek intellectual of our mind's eye, he draws no apparent direct inspiration from the canonical texts of Herodotus, Thucydides and Demosthenes, interested though he is in calling up the substance of ancient historical episodes presented in them[11].

[9] See, above all, Mommsen, *Ges. Schr.* VII, 424 Anm.; see further below at n. 31.

[10] See the digressions *passim*; an instance is cited below in n. 12.

[11] On the other hand, his recollection of Homer seems genuine enough (18.5.7, 19.1.9, 24.6.9; cf. 14.6.21, 15.8.17 et al.), though not all citations are at first hand. On no view of his intellectual background is his knowledge of Homer problematical.

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Herodotus is named but once (22.15.28), as an authority for the pyramids. Since the reference appears in an excursus and Ammianus customarily includes the names cited by his immediate source for these sections of his history[12], it is suspect on general grounds alone. In the special case of the Egyptian pyramids, however, not only was it standard procedure to give Herodotus primacy in a nest of citations (cf. Pliny, *NH* 36, 79), but the verbal similarity linking Ammianus' report with that of Solinus (32.44 p. 147 Mommsen) ensures that the reference to Herodotus is here second-hand.

To be sure, certain other references in Ammianus evoke Herodotus to our minds even though he is not mentioned by name. But an allusion to the Solon-Croesus story (15.5.37), or mention of the names of Artemisia (28.4.5) and the heroes of Marathon (24.6.14), does not indicate the direct use of Herodotus, for these data had long since become common property. Significantly, Herodotus' identity is often submerged in a general reference to past tradition, as when *Graecia fabulosa* is credited with the tale of Doriscus and the computation of an army impossibly large (18.6.23), and when the *memoriae veteres* are alleged to preserve the knowledge of Xerxes' Hellespontine bridges and excavation at Mt. Athos (31.4.7)[13]. In this connection it is illuminating, and should be decisive, that in every instance in which Ammianus presents enough detail to permit an informed judgement, we observe that his impression of the events has been shaped by an intermediate source.

In 28.1.4 we read of the Athenian dramatist, Phrynichus (whose fate became proverbial: Aelian, *VH* 16.17) and of the troubles arising from his play, *The Sack of Miletus*. The information is included that the Milesians chose mass-suicide in preference to captivity. Herodotus 6.18ff. makes no mention of the mass-suicide and by implication negates it (6.19.3). Again, in 17.4.3f., Ammianus reviews the career and fate of Cambyses in Egypt,

quoad vixerat, alieni cupidus et immanis, (sc. *qui*) *Aegypto perrupta aggressus est, ut opes exinde raperet invidendas ne deorum quidem donariis parcens. qui dum inter praedatores turbulente concursat, laxitate praepeditus indumentorum concidit pronus ac suomet pugione, quem aptatum femori dextro gestabat, subita vi ruinae nudato vulneratus paene letaliter interisset.*

Herodotus, however, gave a different set of explanations for the invasion (3.1ff.) and arranged the death-scene differently, making it coincide with Cambyses' intended departure for Susa (3.64.2–4) and placing it in Syria. In

[12] See, e. g., 17.7.11–12 for the reference to Aristotle, Anaxagoras and Anaximander on the causes of earthquakes.

[13] G. Sabbah, *La méthode d'Ammien Marcellin* (Paris 1978) 67, engages in unwarranted speculation when he connects the two passages and infers that *memoriae veteres* represents a positive revaluation of the Father of History who, when these words were written, was no longer regarded by Ammianus as a mouthpiece of *Graecia fabulosa*. It is characteristic of Sabbah to assume profound intellectual relationships between Ammianus and his predecessors and then to enucleate them – as if the speculative analysis validated the premise.

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addition, the circumstances of Cambyses' injuries are not the same (3.64.3). Herodotus has him wound himself by vaulting on a horse, a most vivid detail. Finally, in Herodotus (3.66.2), the wound proves mortal[14]. Another glaring disparity appears in Amm. 23.6.6. He describes Darius' counterrevolution against *seven* magi who stole the kingdom after Cambyses' death. Herodotus asserted repeatedly and emphatically that Smerdis was one of the two magi who appropriated the kingdom (3.61.1ff.), that he did so before the death of Cambyses, and that the number "seven" gives the total of the Persian conspirators, not of the magi. Ammianus' source, in all probability, was Valerius Maximus 9.2 Ext. 6, where the same number of magi is given. A comparable imprecision (though it is less serious) occurs in 15.9.7, where Ammianus miscalls Harpagus Harpalus in erroneous reliance, apparently, on Aulus Gellius 10.16.4[15].

At the very utmost, therefore, one may plead that intensive use of the compilers by Ammianus confused his recollection of Herodotus' narrative, for the *topoi* we associate with Herodotus he best knew by way of derivative sources. But if this be the case, it is arbitrary to maintain that Ammianus at one time had studied his Herodotus carefully, as he should have done had he enjoyed the benefit of a standard Hellenic education.

In the case of Thucydides, although the evidence is too slight to permit us to form a solid judgement about whether Ammianus may have known him at first or at second hand, it clearly does not suggest intensive study. There is no more than a single allusion to an event occurring during the Peloponnesian War, the plague at Athens (Amm. 19.4.4 ≈ Thuc. 2.48.1), and the facts about this event were famous[16]. Similarly, the other explicit citation of Thucydides (Amm. 23.6.75 ≈ Thuc. 1.6) refers to the Athenian abandonment of the custom of bearing arms in civilian life; and this datum also acquired sufficient celebrity (cf. Aristot. *Pol.* II 8.1268 B; Lucian, *Anacharsis* 34) to ensure its remembrance in ethnographical literature, which is apparently where Ammianus found it, for it is embedded in his digression on the Orient. Beyond this, it is apparent that Ammianus resisted the quotation or paraphrase of Thucydidean material, especially the sententiae[17], and though it might be objected that

[14] "Here Amm. does not follow the more general tradition, viz. that Cambyses found his death by an involuntary wound, caused by his own weapon": De Jonge *ad loc.*

[15] Furthermore, in 22.16.4 Ammianus designates Battus as a Spartan, not a Theran, and it is notable that Solinus also called Battius (*sic*) a Lacedaemonian (27.44, p. 125 M). Note also the slip in 23.6.7, where the Bosporus is confused with the Araxes.

[16] See, e. g., Plut. *Moral.* 558 E, Macrob. *Sat.* 4.1.3. It may well have been mentioned by Sallust in the *Historiae*, a work well known to Ammianus. De Jonge *ad loc.* is generous (and constrained only by the possibilities) in his assessment of the writers whom Ammianus might well have consulted for this detail.

[17] 20.8.5 *could* be a reminiscence of Thuc. 1.140.1, but, if so, it more probably reached Ammianus by way of Sallust (in some missing portion of his work). Cf. Ammianus' emulation of Sallust's *fame, miserrima omnium morte* (below), which derives from Thuc. 3.59.3.

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such learning would have been wasted on a Latin-reading audience, the fact remains that Ammianus quotes other Greeks in translation (e. g. Simonides in 14.6.7); moreover, we can see from Sallust how close study of Thucydides can reveal itself even in the Latin tongue. Strong influences manifest themselves, contain them how we will, and Thucydides, assuredly, could have been applied powerfully and usefully in this history. The absence of such influence in Ammianus (whether or not he knew Thucydides) thus points in the same direction (though less conclusively) as Ammianus' apparent ignorance of Thucydides' predecessor, Herodotus.

A more compelling indication of Ammianus' superficial control over the standard material presupposed by his alleged possession of a traditional Greek education arises from the surprising uncertainty and inadequacy of his treatment of Greek rhetorical theory and its leading exponents and practitioners. His references to Demosthenes (at second hand) and to Isocrates[18] (Lysias is not mentioned) do not suggest that he ever devoted himself to the study of these writers. When we compare the virtually total absence of the names of the canonical Greek orators (by an author prone to adduce multiple citations when they are quite unnecessary) with the superabundance of his allusions to Cicero, above all[19], the impression that Ammianus was oriented in Latin letters, not in Greek, is difficult to shake. This impression, moreover, is fully corroborated by what, on any other theory of Ammianus' intellectual background, should be regarded as a striking anomaly: Ammianus is peculiarly indifferent to the legacy of the ancient Athenians, whose city-state, like that of Rome for the Latin intellectual, called forth unbounded admiration and unstinted praise from the liberally educated Hellenes of the post-classical period. In Ammianus, the Athenians are treated without evident respect, and only cursorily. Thus, in addition to the references to the Athenian repudiation of arms in archaic times (23.6.75), Phrynichus' drama (28.1.4), and the plague at Athens (19.4.4), mention is made of the Amazon invasion (22.8.18), the purification of Delos by the Athenians (22.12.8), and the "Salamis oracle" (23.5.9)[20]. Now four of these references appear in digressions, and two others are *topoi* (the oracle and Phrynichus)[21]. Striking is the different attitude of the

[18] The Demosthenes citation in 30.1.23 derives from Gellius 10.19.3. For 30.4.5 see below. Isocrates is named in 30.8.6.

[19] Cicero is named 21 times and is quoted or paraphrased more than 300 times. See the citations printed in E. Owens, *Phraseological Parallels and Borrowings in Ammianus Marcellinus from earlier Latin authors* (Diss. London n. d.) pp. 48–149. Gellius was another favorite, sometimes quoted closely and sometimes thoroughly reworked.

[20] Miletus (22.8.12) and Byzantium (22.8.8) are identified as Athenian colonies. For the error about Byzantium, which occurs in other fourth century writers, see Wagner (cf. above p. 328 n. 1) *ad loc.*

[21] For *dubia oracula* see Cicero, *De divin.* 2.56.115–116, where Croesus' oracle, but not the Salamis oracle, is given. J. Fontaine, *Ammien Marcellin* IV Commentaire (Paris 1977) 49 n. 109, *assumes* that the latter is a "probable reminiscence" of Hdt.7.140 f. The purification of Delos is

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emperor Julian who, though an enthusiast, hardly overstates in his writings the centrality of Athens as a symbol of the Greek intellectual life and heritage (e. g. *Misopog.* 348 BC)[22]. In a word, Ammianus does not behave in the manner, or display the outlook, of a man equipped with the advantages and the prejudices of a traditional Greek education.

It is not likely to be accidental, therefore, that the single passage Ammianus devotes to the subject of Greek forensic rhetoric (30.4.3–5) is seriously inadequate. In connection with current abuse of the lawcourts, Ammianus writes as follows:

hanc professionem oratorum forensium πολιτικῆς μορίου εἴδωλον, *id est civilitatis particulae umbram, vel adulationis partem quartam esse definit amplitudo Platonis, Epicurus autem* κακοτεχνίαν *nominans inter artes numerat malas, Tisias suasionis opificem esse memorat assentiente Leontino Gorgia.*

These quotations add glitter, but they define rhetoric or its subcategory, deliberative oratory, not forensic oratory. Ammianus then continues with an even more disconcerting observation:

quam (sc. *artem*) *a veteribus ita determinatam* [!] *orientalium quorundam versutia ad usque bonorum extulit odium* [!], *unde etiam retinaculis temporis praestituti frenatur.*

The assertion is factually false: that the Athenians early submitted to a time-limit is evident from their speeches. Nor is the reference to easterners intelligible as it stands. Furthermore, although the tenses he uses suggest that he is telescoping ancient and modern times, the remark in fact looks very like a hasty adaptation of Cicero, *Brutus* 13,51, where Cicero spoke of the eastern debasement of style in a roughly similar developmental sketch:

at vero extra Graeciam magna dicendi studia fuerunt maximique huic laudi habiti honores inlustre oratorum nomen reddiderunt. nam ut semel e Piraeo eloquentia evecta est, omnis peragravit insulas atque ita peregrinata tota Asia est, ut se externis oblineret moribus omnemque illam salubritatem Atticae dictionis et quasi sanitatem perderet ac loqui paene dedisceret.

Ammianus now proceeds with an allusion to the good old days when orators were educated, honest and eloquent,

ut Demosthenes, quo dicturo concursus audiendi causa ex tota Graecia fieri solitos monumentis Atticis continetur, et Callistratus, quem nobilem illam super

noticed in connection with Julian's purification of Castalia. The ultimate source is Thuc. 3.104 or Hdt.1.64. Incidentally, Musonius is described in 27.9.6 as *Athenis Atticis antehac magister rhetoricus* and, more relevant here, Celsus is praised in 22.9.13 for his Athenian education (*iam inde a studiis cognitum Atticis*). Since the point of this remark is simply to praise Celsus in terms universally understood, it expresses no particular affection for the university city on the part of Ammianus.

[22] See, e. g., P. Athanassiadi-Fowden, *Julian and Hellenism* (Oxford 1981) 51.

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Oropo causam, qui locus in Euboea est[23], *perorantem idem Demosthenes Academia cum Platone relicta sectatus est, ut Hyperides et Aeschines et Andocides et Dinarchus et Antiphon ille Rhamnusius, quem ob defensum negotium omnium primum antiquitas prodidit accepisse mercedem. nec minus apud Romanos etc.*

However, unlike the Latins now introduced, who, thanks to the *Brutus* (30,113–116), at least parade in the correct chronological order, the Athenians appear in an impressionistic sequence, perhaps because this passage too is built on quotation. Ammianus borrowed the reference to Demosthenes' popularity almost verbatim from Cicero, *Brutus* 84,289[24], just as the anecdote associating Demosthenes, Plato and Callistratus derives from Gellius 3.13[25]. The source of Ammianus' information about Antiphon is unknown[26].

The difficulty is not with Ammianus' extensive reliance on quotation, which is altogether in his manner, but in his inability to provide a cogent and reasoned presentation, even succinctly. It is possible that he was indifferent, judging his audience to be more interested in the pyrotechnics of his running quotations (assuming that he has not lifted the entire medley out of some other source) than in an expert summary, but we are left, nevertheless, with the negligent and uninformed treatment of a subject in which, *ex hypothesi*, his training was solid. The evidence, such as it is (and it includes a denigration of rhetoric in 16.5.7) does not corroborate the conventional hypothesis.

Both in general and in particular, therefore, it proves impossible to build the case from his work that Ammianus controlled the standard Greek classics in any meaningful degree[27]. Otherwise imposing references to Anaxagoras, Bacchylides, Democritus, Didymus Chalcenterus, Eratosthenes, Euctemon, Hecataeus, Heraclitus, Hesiod, Isocrates, Menander, Meton, Simonides, Theognis and others, including those already named, are mostly ornamental and

[23] *An lippis haec ignotum (sc. Oropem esse in confinio Atticae et Boeotiae)?* Wagner *ad loc.* thus assumes a gloss.

[24] *Cum Demosthenes dicturus est, ut concursus audiendi causa ex tota Graecia fierent.* In view of Ammianus' resort to Cicero here, his addition of the next three words is instructive and disturbing.

[25] According to Gellius, who cites Hermippus (*FHG* III 49), Demosthenes, while frequenting Plato's Academy, followed a crowd to hear Callistratus. "*Venit," inquit* (sc. *Hermippus*), "*atque audit Callistratum nobilem illam* τὴν περὶ Ὀρωποῦ δίκην *dicentem atque ita motus et demultus et captus est, ut Callistratum iam inde sectari coeperit, Academiam cum Platone reliquerit.*"

[26] Possibly it derives from the tradition reported in Plut. *Moral.* 832 C: καί τινας λόγους τοῖς δεομένοις τῶν πολιτῶν συνέγραφεν εἰς τοὺς ἐν τοῖς δικαστηρίοις ἀγῶνας πρῶτος ἐπὶ τοῦτο τραπείς, ὥσπερ τινές φασι.

[27] Matthews, *The Roman Empire of Ammianus* (n. 7 above) 462, speaks of the "deeper affinity of Ammianus with Greek historiographical ideals", a concept much belabored by Sabbah, *La méthode* (n. 13 above) *passim.* If we substitute the term "Graeco-Roman historiographical ideals" and interpret it loosely and selectively, we would be on firmer ground. (What exactly does Matthews mean, for instance, when he speaks of Ammianus' "Herodotean spirit"? The comparison is very unfair to Herodotus).

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usually derivative. Their suspect nature will readily be conceived if one keeps in mind that the sole quotation from Demosthenes which appears in Ammianus' history (30.1.23) he found and translated from a page of Aulus Gellius (10.19.3). But deception was not intended: it is as his mention of Lucilius in Cicero's quotation about the single burst of laughter of Crassus. The past lived in the present; the actions and *dicta* of the ancients, long remembered by the tradition to which Ammianus was heir, required preservation and transmission by him as well.

Since, by contrast, Ammianus' control of Latin literature is impressive, his choice of Latin as the language of his history would seem to be the natural expression of his adoption of the Roman literary heritage. For us, naturally, the question of chief importance is the quality of his knowledge of the great historians of Rome, Sallust, Livy and Tacitus. These writers, of course, commanded the field of Roman historiography, and in a very real sense Ammianus' knowledge of their work is a measure of his own authenticity.

For he constantly hearkens back to their words, or to the events they described, and at the close of his work he unmistakably takes his place, as the continuator of Tacitus, in that great series.

The frequent occurrence in Ammianus of the phraseology of his predecessors makes some level of familiarity certain. Ammianus repeats at least some seventy phrases of Livy, as many again of Tacitus, and even more of Sallust, in the eighteen books which remain to us of the original thirty-one[28]. Since considerable portions of all three of his predecessors are also no longer extant but presumably enjoyed proportionate representation, the interrelationships must have been many. The main disagreement existing today concerns the more precise explanation for the presence of these parallels. Older scholars, chiefly Martin Hertz and Otto Seeck, believed that the allusions were purposeful[29]. On this view, which has been revived (with qualifications) by Hermann Tränkle and Klaus Rosen[30], among others, Ammianus mentally juxtaposed

[28] The most recent major study of the "borrowings" is that of Owens, cited above in n. 19. Fundamental were the works of M. Hertz, in *Hermes* 8 (1874) 257–302 (Ammianus' use of Gellius), and in *De Ammiani Marcellini Studiis Sallustianis*, Ind. Lect. Vratisl. 1874. The important study by E. Cornelius on Ammianus' use of Tacitus appeared in *Progr. Wetzlar 1888*, 17 ff. See further Schanz-Hosius, *Geschichte der römischen Literatur* IV I² (Munich 1914) 104 f. More recent work is noticed and discussed by K. Rosen, *Ammianus Marcellinus* (Darmstadt 1982) 92.

[29] For Hertz see the previous note. Seeck, *RE* I No. 4 col 1851, supposed that Ammianus kept a record of special phrases in a "well-arranged *Zettelkasten*." Fundamental to Hertz, Seeck and others, was the conviction that Ammianus, the Antiochene Greek, needed help for his Latin. The utter impracticality of the technique imputed to Ammianus (in no way comparable to the memorandum containing old words which Sallust used) should have been apparent to Seeck, for the sheer volume of Ammianus' allusions makes arrangement in any fashion easier said than done.

[30] Tränkle, *A & A* 11 (1962) 21ff.; for Rosen see n. 28 above.

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(and intended his readers to juxtapose) the original context with his own, harvesting irony, paradox, wit, etc. from the confrontation. However, proponents of an opposing and apparently now regnant view – Mommsen, Schanz, Hagendahl and, more recently, Blockley[31] – allege that the occurrence of parallel phrases is almost always at random and without intended significance. Adherents of this opinion explain the presence of such language as a by-product of Ammianus' study and consolidation of a suitable vocabulary for the writing of his own history in Latin. The phrases, it follows, were not intended to evoke their original authors and it may even be doubted whether Ammianus was conscious of the identity of his models when he echoed their words, for he did so more or less instinctively.

Now it certainly must be granted, against the view of Hertz and his followers, that the preponderance of the allusions, if that is what they really are, lack obvious point; and purposeless echoes seem almost a contradiction in terms. But the alternative view has some features of its own which are even more unacceptable. For obvious reasons, the quotation of one author by another is usually regarded *ipso facto* as intentional reminiscence. By denying that Ammianus engaged in this process in spite of the multiple signs of its application, we detach him in a bizarre fashion from his working memory and from the ability to discriminate the styles of the writers he is conceded to have studied.

Critical to this view is the circular assumption that Ammianus' control of Latin was precarious because he was a born Greek. As Schanz-Hosius wrote, "although Latin was familiar to him as the official language of the army, he did not yet possess the skill to handle Latin in its literary form; Ammianus sought to acquire the skill from many Latin books. His phraseology is constructed from distinct reminiscence, as only a good memory can provide. The influence of Cicero, Tacitus, Gellius and other authors is met with everywhere; his vocabulary therefore becomes variegated because it is composed of the most various elements"[32]. It is notable that a special explanation has been invoked to account for a phenomenon for which contemporary analogues existed: Ausonius and (the Alexandrian) Claudian habitually reproduce the language of Vergil and Statius, but the history of (the "Antiochene") Ammianus is a *tour de force* retaining the impress of impetuous reading and undiscriminated assimilation. The hypothesis also rests on presuppositions that are questionable at best. For example, one scholar denies that parallels with Tacitus were intentional because Tacitus was insufficiently well known in the fourth century to be recognized if quoted[33]. But, of course, our only means for

[31] Mommsen, *Ges. Schr.* VII, 424 Anm.; Schanz-Hosius (n. 28 above); H. Hagendahl, *Studia Ammianea* (Diss. Uppsala 1921) 1-2; H.R. Blockley, *Latomus* 32 (1973) 63f. (on Ammianus' use of Tacitus).

[32] *Gesch. d. röm. Lit.* IV 1² (Munich 1914) 102.

[33] Blockley, *Latomus* 32 (1973) 64.

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estimating whether Tacitus was seriously read in Ammianus' time is to observe the frequency with which allusions to his works are made, and to deny the possibility of such allusions on the ground that they cannot have been perceived by others substitutes dogma for empiricism.

Beginning with Sallust, let us consider some of the actual language bearing on the question. Quotation of some examples of the most non-committal parallels – those most likely to have been the involuntary product of his assimilation of Sallustian vocabulary – will identify concretely the type of similarity which is most ambiguous. To put it differently, these examples constitute the best evidence for Ammianus' alleged exploitation of an acquired vocabulary. If they stood alone the question of Ammianus' technique would be moot.

Ammianus	*Sallust*
14.1.2 male suetos	*Hist.* 3.17 male iam adsuetum
14.3.4 admissi flagitii metu exagitati	*Hist.* 1.77.7 scelerum conscientia exagitati
15.6.3 fortis . . . et fidus (miles)	*Cat.* 20.3 vos cognovi fortes fidosque mihi
15.8.2 et al. noxarum conscientia	*Hist.* 2.87 D 5 conscientia noxarum
20.11.14 cupiditate potiundi oppidi	*BJ* 37.4 cupidine caecus ob thesauros oppidi potiundi
24.1.2 per locorum insolentium	*BJ* 50.6 insolentia loci
25.8.2 immane quo quantoque ardore	*Hist.* 2.44 immane quantum animi exarsere
31.3.6 verum longe aliter quam rebatur evenit	*BJ* 7.3 sed ea res longe aliter ac ratus erat
31.12.5 quid facto opus esset deliberabat	*Cat.* 46.2 quid facto opus esset (dubitans)

It is clear that the frequent presence of allusion of this type cannot resolve the question of whether they are intentional reminiscence or reflexive echoes. It is equally apparent from the context in which they appear that if they served a purpose, it was limited to the evocation of Sallustian language and nothing more. In that case it would follow, at most, that they were directed at readers with a firm control of Sallust's language who would enjoy the fragmentary reminiscence purely for its own sake. Now this possibility, though conceivable, is scarcely worth pursuing unless something more is present to make it realistic. In short, these parallels, if they are to be taken seriously, must demonstrably have been arranged or distributed in an unmistakable environment of quotation and reminiscence. The reader must observe indisputable signs of Sallustian quotation before he will become attentive to more fragmen-

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tary echoes – though it should be understood that the reader will probably have noticed, even without this assistance, that the special language is classical and is stamped with a certain Sallustian impress.

It seems self-evident that an ancient reader with no presuppositions except those guided by the modest imitations exemplified above would naturally conclude that they were *intentional* reminiscences of Sallust only if he simultaneously observed the unambiguous operation of this technique throughout the work. This condition is, in fact, fully met. No one familiar with Sallust could have overlooked very many of the allusions in the following set, especially after he was persuaded by his discovery of a few first examples that they were pervasive. For instance, even a nodding reader with the necessary background will have noted the phrase *ad requisita naturae secedens* (23.6.79 ≈ *Hist. inc.* 3, p. 201 Maurenbrecher), which Quintilian (8.6.59) specifically denoted as a Sallustian expression[34]. Another famous phrase, already echoed by Pomponius Mela 2.92 (cf. Pliny, *NH* 3.20) was Sallust's *Saguntini fide atque aerumnis incliti prae mortalibus* (*Hist.* 2.64 M), which appears in Ammianus as *Saguntinis memorabilibus aerumnis et fide* (15.10.10). Equally well known was Sallust's dictum (*Hist.* 3.42 = Plut. *Luc.* 11.6) that the Romans first observed the camel in the war against Mithridates. We know the remark from Plutarch, whom it puzzled; Livy rejected it by implication (37.40.12 [190 B.C.]); Ammianus accepts it with emphasis (23.6.56). Similarly, Sallust (*Hist.* 3.65) speaks of the sweetness of the waters of the Pontus, an assertion repeated by Macrobius (*Sat.* 7.12.34) as well as by Ammianus (22.8.46). One of the two passages Hertz[35] believed to be conclusive of his theory involves the specific language Sallust and Ammianus used to describe mail armor:

Sall. *Hist.* 4.66: *qui praegrediebantur, equites cataphracti, ferrea omni specie; 65 equis paria operimenta erant, ‹nam›que linteo ferreas laminas in modum plumae adnexuerant*

Amm. 24.2.10: *tum defensores . . . validissime resistebant ferrea nimirum facie omni, quia lammineae singulis membrorum lineamentis cohaerenter aptatae fido operimento totam hominis speciem contegebant;* 24.4.15 *hostem undique lamminis ferreis in modum tenuis plumae contectum;* cf. 24.6.8.

A list of some further examples of this type can now usefully be given:

Ammianus	*Sallust*
15.8.1 ad internecionem barbaris vastantibus universa	*Hist.* 2.98.9 Hispaniam citeriorem . . . ad internecionem vastavimus

[34] The parallel in Amm.23.6.76 (in a similar context) just three sentences before, with Sallust *BJ* 80.6 quoted in the list of parallels before should have focused the attention of an ordinary reader more sharply on the possibility of allusion because of the close conjunction of the two echoes.

[35] *De . . . Studiis Sallustianis* (n. 28 above) 12 f. The other compelling reminiscence (as he supposed) was Amm.26.6.16 ≈ *Hist.*1.55.22.

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22.8.10 (Pontus) in speciem Scythici arcus	*Hist.* 3.63 speciem efficit Scythici arcus
23.6.76 pro opibus quisque asciscens matrimonia plura vel pauca, unde apud eos per libidines varias caritas dispersa torpescit	*BJ* 80.6 singuli pro opibus quisque quam plurimas uxores, denas alii, alii pluris . . . habent . . . ita animus multitudine distrahitur
26.6.16 ad hoc igitur dehonestamentum honorum omnium ludibriose sublatus et ancillari adulatione beneficii allocutus auctores	*Hist.* 1.55.22 Fufidius ancilla turpis, bonorum omnium dehonestamentum
28.1.2 carptim, ut quaeque memoria digna sunt, explanabo; 14.4.2 super quorum moribus licet . . . memini retulisse, tamen nunc quoque pauca de isdem expediam carptim	*Cat.* 4.2 carptim ut quaeque memoria digna videbantur perscribere; 5 de quoius hominis moribus pauca prius explananda sunt; *BJ* 5.3 priusquam . . . expedio, pauca supra repetam
28.3.2 cum strenui militis munia et praeclari ducis curas expleret; cf. 12.24	*Cat.* 60.4 strenui militis et boni imperatoris officia simul exequebatur
28.4.3 irritamenta gulae	*BJ* 89.7 inritamenta gulae; cf. Tac. *Hist.* 2.62
29.1.8 semper officio locoque, quem retinebat, superior videbatur	*BJ* 63.5 ut ampliore quam gerebat (magistratu) dignus haberetur
29.2.21 cervicibus Asiae totius insedit	*Hist.* 2.98.4 hostisque in cervicibus iam Italiae agentis

Nor is this all. Ammianus' work is studded with peculiarly Sallustian formulae for the reckoning of the seasons[36]; and he also reproduces the phraseology used by Sallust for transitional passages[37]. The total effect, one may suppose, would have pursuaded a fourth century reader that Ammianus' object was to evoke Sallust in his work. Modern doubters, however, insist that something even more is needed: evidence of calculated interplay between his text and that of his predecessors. The requirement is perhaps excessive: a writer whose method arguably involves the deliberate evocation of Sallust's language need not necessarily feel bound to comply with our expectation that he must deploy more complex and ambitious imitations, for technique is a mark of temperament and taste, and who are we to dictate the lengths to which "proper emulation" must be taken? In any case, precisely this seems provided by Amm. 17.9.4.

Fame, ignavissimo mortis genere, is language (cf. 25.7.4) which Hertz associated with Sallust *Hist.* 2.98.1, *fame, miserrima omnium morte.* But the association with Sallust is considerably more intricate than Hertz supposed. In Ammianus these words appear in a speech attributed to Julian's soldiers and

[36] E. g. Amm.17.13.28, 19.11.2, 19.9.1, 30.5.14, with *Hist.inc.* 38 M
[37] E. g. Amm.15.2.6 with *BJ* 4.9, *Cat.*7.7.

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are spoken in direct oration. The soldiers compare their miserable condition and state of near-famine with the extraordinary service they have performed for the state:

Quo trahimur spe meliorum abolita olim quidem dura et perpessu asperrima per nives tolerantes et acumina crudelium pruinarum? sed nunc, pro nefas, cum ultimis hostium fatis instamus ***fame ignavissimo mortis genere*** *tabescentes?*

Sallust's remark about hunger was also embedded in direct oration, Pompey's letter to the Senate of 75 B.C. The general similarity of context is close: as a newly installed general, like Julian, Pompey requests assistance for his needy army from the Senate just as Julian's army had demanded it of him.

The parallel context, together with the reminiscence, would ordinarily suggest to us that a direct allusion was intended. But there is more, enough, I think, to make the proposition unassailable. Ammianus underscored the allusion by adding still another from the identical place. For Pompey's letter begins as follows:

Si ***adversus vos patriamque et deos penatis tot labores et pericula suscepissem****, quotiens a prima adulescentia ductu meo scelestissimi hostes fusi et vobis salus quaesita est, nihil amplius in absentem me statuissetis, quam adhuc agitis, patres conscripti, quem contra aetatem proiectum ad bellum saevissimum cum exercitu optimo merito, quantum est in vobis,* ***fame, miserrima omnium morte****, confecistis.*

Observe now the language Ammianus used in the sentence directly following the one in 17.9.4 already quoted:

et ne qui nos turbarum existimet concitores, pro vita loqui sola testamur non aurum neque argentum petentes, quae olim nec contrectare potuimus nec videre, ita nobis negata, ***velut contra rem publicam tot suscepisse labores et pericula*** *confutatis!*

The interlocking parallels, *fame, suscepisse labores,* which Ammianus has reworked into separate sentences in reverse order, leave no doubt that the imitation is intentional; it is a studied adaptation of a Sallustian model requiring its recollection in order to be appreciated.

The presence of one intentional parallel of Sallust will not, of course, prove the operation of design in all others. Nevertheless, we have gained a new perspective from which to view the collective evidence, and in this light the opinion expressed by Mommsen and those who follow him becomes even harder to accept. If we have a multiplicity of more or less distinctive allusions on the one hand, and an all but explicit adaptation on the other, we must assume at the very least that Ammianus was not wholly mechanical in his reproduction of Sallustian language. Once this is admitted, the best case for "automatic recall" dwindles to the most peripheral examples of Sallustian usage. But the more striking parallels and collocations, even on this view, would now seem to fall into another category, and should be judged on their

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own merits. Thus, for instance, in another speech, one given by Julian in 23.5.19, two Sallustian reminiscences from different works are placed back-to-back, an emplacement not normally characteristic of even the most prodigious associative memory[38]. Let us consider, therefore, whether the case of Sallust is unique or whether something comparable can be elicited from Ammianus' use of Livy and Tacitus.

We may take for granted that a large number of parallels exist[39] which, since they are devoid of material substance, leave open the question of Ammianus' intent, and proceed with examples of arguably more distinct allusions to Livy and Tacitus.

Ammianus	*Livy*
14.5.4 accedebant . . . proximorum . . . blanditiae exaggerantium incidentia	1.9.16 accedebant blanditiae virorum factum purgantium
16.12.53 intactis ferro corporibus	1.25.11 intactum ferro corpus
21.4.1 in unum omni cogitatione intenta	40.5.2 ad id unum omnes cogitationes intendit
24.4.19 nihil tam leve est, quod non interdum etiam contra sperata rerum afferat momenta magnarum	25.18.3 sed in bello nihil tam leve est, quod non magnae interdum rei momentum faciat
26.10.14 opum satietas cepit et caedis	27.49.8 sanguinis caedisque ceperat satietas
31.2.11 ad omnem auram incidentis spei novae perquam mobiles	29.3.13 gente ad omnem auram spei mobili atque infida
	Tacitus
18.2.18 ut sunt fluxioris fidei barbari	*Hist.* 3.48 fluxa, ut est barbaris, fide
20.4.14 nocte vero coeptante in apertum erupere discidium	*Ann.* 1.28 noctem minacem et in scelus erupturam
21.12.20 acerrimus belli instinctor	*Hist.* 4.68 acerrimo instinctore belli
27.9.2 transferendaeque in alios invidiae artifex	*Hist.* 2.86 serendae in alios invidiae artifex
28.1.57 is urbanarum rerum status, ut ita dixerim, fuit	*Ann.* 1.16 hic rerum urbanarum status erat

[38] *Adero ubique vobis adiumento numinis sempiterni, imperator et antesignanus et conturmalis ominibus secundis, ut reor. at si fortuna versabilis in pugna me usquam fuderit, mihi vero pro Romano orbe memet vovisse sufficiet* . . . Sall. *BJ* 85.47: *egomet in agmine [a] ut in proelio consultor idem et socius periculi vobiscum adero, meque mos in omnibus rebus iuxta geram.* Sall. *Hist.*2.47.10: *Adsum en C. Cotta consul! Facio quod saepe maiores asperis bellis fecere, voveo dedoque me pro re publica!*

[39] See G. B. A. Fletcher, *RPh* 11 (1937) 383–86 (Livy), 389–392 (Tacitus), for the prior literature and his additions to the lists. Owens (above n. 19) 194–96, 203–207, supplies other parallels.

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30.1.5 doli iam prudens	*Hist.* 2.25 doli prudens
31.8.6 rapinis et caedibus sanguineque et incendiis et liberorum corporum corruptelis omnia foedissime permiscentes	*Hist.* 3.73 inrumpunt Vitelliani et cuncta sanguine ferro flammisque miscent

For those who consider that parallels such as these prove not intentional allusion, but (merely) the random expression of an undifferentiated set of phrases which happened to stick in Ammianus' very retentive mind, we may seek further evidence along the lines adopted in respect to Ammianus-Sallust. To consider Livy first, his language in 7.32.11 may well satisfy the condition, for it literally underlies Ammianus' choice of words in 15.8.13. Livy allows the Roman general, Valerius, to compare himself, in a speech, with his magniloquent but ineffective Samnite antagonist, *qui audiendus dumtaxat magnificus adhortator sit.* In Ammianus, also in a speech, Constantius urges the new Caesar, Julian, to behave as the very opposite type, and his words sound almost identically, except for the critical omission of one letter in the gerund: *audendi in tempore consideratus hortator.* The echo and word-play seem unmistakable, but it all depends on the recollection of Livy's exact words. In another instance, 25.1.14, Ammianus quotes Livy directly on the terrifying aspect of the war-elephant:

Amm. 25.1.14 ad quorum stridorem odoremque et insuetum aspectum magis equi terrebantur	Livy 30.18.7 ad quorum stridorem odoremque et aspectum territi equi vanum equestre auxilium fecerunt

Moreover, Ammianus reinforces the allusion by adding just below (25.1.15) a remark about Hasdrubal and his technique of stopping an elephant dead in his tracks: *exploratum est enim aliquando ab Hasdrubale Hannibalis fratre ita citius vitam huiusmodi adimi beluarum.* This Livy described in 27.49.2: *ea celerrima via mortis in tantae molis belua inventa erat, ubi regentis imperium sprevissent, primusque id Hasdrubal instituerat* . . . The association with the Second Punic War, in Livy's language, could not have been made more distinctly unless Ammianus had actually cited him by name. He left this identification to his reader.

A grander evocation of Livy occurs in 25.9.4–5. G. B. A. Fletcher had noticed that the phrase *silentium triste* appears both in Ammianus 26.6.18 and in Livy 1.29.3, where it contributes its part to Livy's memorable description of the forced evacuation of Alba Longa. The interesting question arises whether Ammianus remembered the phrase but forgot the author and the context from which he learned it, and the answer appears in his narration of a closely comparable event, the abandonment of Nisibis by Jovian in 25.9. Julian's successor had given up to Sapor this well-fortified place to save the army (as he thought) from annihilation, and the inhabitants of Nisibis consequently

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relinquish their city in the greatest distress. The two descriptions are closely comparable:

Livy 1.29.4–5: *ut vero iam equitum clamor exire iubentium instabat, iam fragor tectorum . . . audiebatur pulvisque . . . omnia impleverat, raptim quibus quisque poterat elatis cum larem ac penates tectaque,* ***in quibus natus quisque educatusque esset****, relinquentes exirent,* ***iam continens agmen migrantium impleverat vias****, et conspectus aliorum mutua miseratione integrabat lacrimas, vocesque etiam miserabiles exaudiebantur mulierum praecipue, cum obsessa ab armatis templa augusta praeterirent ac velut captos relinquerent deos.*

Amm. 25.9.5: *appositis itaque compulsoribus mortem, si qui distulerit egredi, minitantibus moenia permixta sunt lamentis et luctu et per omnia civitatis membra una vox cunctorum erat gementium, cum laceraret crines matrona, exsul fuganda laribus,* ***in quibus nata erat et educata****, orbataque mater liberis vel coniuge viduata procul ab eorum manibus pelleretur et turba flebilis postes penatium amplexa vel limina lacrimabat,* ***exin variae complentur viae****.*

It can hardly be denied that the similarity of the two passages goes well beyond phraseological echo[40]: Alba Longa is the model for Nisibis, and we therefore observe once again that Ammianus is in control of the text of his predecessor, for the detailed remembrance of a scene presented by a writer entails the correlative recollection of the author of the scene. One should observe, at the same time, that Ammianus' literary dependency, interesting as it is, contains a very disturbing element. The author of a dramatic episode he personally had observed has modeled his description of the event on a figment of Livy's imagination.

Ammianus' employment of Tacitean language is consistent with his use of Sallust and Livy and, more important for present purposes, the evidence for a comparable superimposition of texts, though slender, is also compelling. It was Wölfflin[41] who noted the similarity of Ammianus 16.4.2, *murorum intuta firmata*, with Tacitus, *Hist.* 3.76, *non intuta moenium firmare*, a collocation apparently not occurring elsewhere in Latin (except for Ammianus). The language figures in Ammianus' account of Julian's industrious defense of Sens (Senones) against the Alamanni; Tacitus uses it to emphasize the indifferent attitude of the defenders of Terracina when confronted by Vitellius' hostile advance against them. As with Ammianus' adaptation of Livy's phrase *audiendi verbis dumtaxat* to express a reverse meaning, the employment of this expression in a polar opposite is intriguing. However, it is the presence of still another phrase culled from the same Tacitean sentence which locks the two texts together in mutual relationship:

[40] The correspondence has been noticed by Tränkle, *A & A* 11 (1962) 24 n. 8 a. This carefully wrought passage also contains an allusion to Vergil, *Aeneid* 2.490, 3.351.

[41] *Philologus* 29 (1870) 559.

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Amm. 16.4.2: *clausa ergo urbe* ***murorumque intuta parte firmata*** *ipse cum armatis* ***die noctuque*** *inter propugnacula visebantur et pinnas ira exundante substridens, cum erumpere saepe conatus paucitate praesentis manus impediretur.*

Tacit. *Hist.* 3.76: *praeerat . . . Julianus . . . Apollinaris . . . lascivia socordiaque gladiatorum magis quam ducum similes. non vigilias egere, non* ***intuta moenium firmare; noctu dieque*** *fluxi et amoena litorum personantes, in ministerium luxus dispersis militibus, de bello tantum inter convivia loquebantur.*

The presence of *die noctuque* in the same part of the sentence in which Tacitus gives *noctu dieque* announces the textual filiation. The very artificiality of the double allusion, each of which unites in pointing a substantial contrast in the meaning of each passage, is beyond coincidence. The skillful adaptation, to be sure, presupposes a learned reader and the currency of Tacitus, but we have no reason to doubt the existence of a happy few or the availability of Tacitus in learned circles, and if so much be granted, Ammianus may be allowed to have aimed in this manner at their gratification.

Indeed, even without this evidence, the case against Ammianus' use of Tacitus has always seemed to require special pleading. Although (in the extant material) Ammianus did not mention Tacitus by name (Sallust is named in 15.12.6, a digression), the words at the end of his history assuredly indicate that he regarded himself as Tacitus' continuator. To have carried his history, as he stated in 31.16.9, from the principate of Nerva to the death of Valens was to extend the *historical* record (in explicit contrast to the work of the biographers: 28.4.14) from the point Tacitus had left it – a decision which presupposes that the *Historiae* of Tacitus, at least, were available to the fourth century reading public. Furthermore, although opinion may fluctuate as to whether the general influence of Tacitus on Ammianus is or is not substantial[42], Ammianus' imitation of Tacitean phraseology, as we have seen, is clearly marked. Nor is this all. Present in Ammianus are three allusions to Tacitus which seem pointed, and are both verbal and contextual. (1) Ammianus 25.4.7 bestows on Julian the same compliment Tacitus, *Hist.* 4.5, paid to Helvidius Priscus, *opum contemptor*[43]. (2) Ammianus 21.5.5 has Julian apply to his own revolt the words with which (in a similar type of speech) Mucianus urged Vespasian to revolt from Vitellius (*Hist.* 2.76): *si fortuna coeptis adfuerit*; (3) in Ammianus 20.4.14, the night before Julian's acclamation – *nocte vero coeptante in apertum erupere discidium* – recalls the night of the Pannonian rebellion facing Drusus (*Ann.* 1.28): *noctem minacem et in scelus erupturam.* Like Drusus, though with

[42] For a negative assessment see Blockley, *Latomus* 32 (1973) 63ff.

[43] It is significant that just before these words, Tacitus writes *cunctis vitae officiis aequabilis*, while Ammianus, in the same position, has *placidus*. These words are virtual synonyms.

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a different result, Julian initially resisted the soldiers' mutiny, and a general similarity invests the two passages.

Once it is admitted that these parallels are true ones (and this has not been denied by the skeptics), the dispute really is at an end. For it is a false trail to argue that the allusions are *unintended* when at the same time it is conceded that the "similarity of material led Ammianus to recall the Tacitean passages from which he selected certain words that he thought suitable for his own use"[44]. That, of course, is what we ordinarily mean by the term "allusion" – an intentional reminiscence of someone's language – and so, in effect, what Mommsen's followers come to in the end (by way of a redefinition of terms) is the extraordinary proposition that Ammianus consciously made use of his predecessors but did not expect his readers to be aware of it.

To consider whether Ammianus "intended" his allusions to be understood as "allusions" seems pointlessly to reverse the ordinary rules of evidence which we apply in determining literary affiliations. The (unsupported) allegation that Tacitus (and the others) were not well enough known in the period to be recognized when recalled in the manner used by Ammianus can be dismissed without trepidation. We know, certainly, that a copy of Tacitus was available to our author, surely not uniquely. If, therefore, Ammianus managed to conceive of allusions, there will have been others capable of recognizing them. As Ammianus was aware, some in his potential audience counted as *scrupulosi lectores antiquitatum* (16.7.9). A class of literati flourished in centers extending from Bordeaux to the Latin chair at Constantinople and beyond to Alexandria, men who had devoted a lifetime to scholarship (as it was then understood) and its perpetuation. The proper inference, therefore, is that material evoking Tacitus by context and by language requires that Ammianus supposed that some of his readership, at least theoretically, would be capable of making the desired associations.

Perhaps one can go further, and attempt an answer to the curious question of why Ammianus so steadfastly refused to mention Sallust, Livy and Tacitus, though he cites them so very often. On the one or two occasions when Ammianus admits to his use of reminiscence, he seems to do so in a self-conscious manner, prefacing the adaptation with the words *ut ita dicerem* or *dixerim*. Once he does this *in propria persona*, quoting the colorless Tacitean formula *is urbanarum rerum status fuit* (28.1.57), another time he makes Julian, in a speech (20.7.9), qualify his adoption of a Ciceronian expression (*Catil*. 4, 11: *tutissimo me muro saeptum esse arbitrabor*): *libero pectoris muro, ut ita dixerim, saeptus*. Now these qualifications come very close to the

[44] Blockley, *Latomus* 32 (1973) 64, who also admits (*ibidem*) that a "few of the phrases in Ammianus might have been intended to evoke the passage of Tacitus from which they were taken."

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acknowledgement of the presence of a quotation and are analogous, therefore, to the three famous reminiscences of Vergil (15.9.1, 19.9.7, 31.4.6; cf. 17.4.5). What this seems to suggest is that Ammianus intentionally practiced a technique of unannounced adaptation of the major Latin writers, but that he did so within certain parameters – parameters which excluded the crass exploitation of what to the initiated were obvious clichés. In other words, we may infer the operation of a sort of rule from the few exceptions to it in Ammianus[45], and we may infer therefrom that the allusions which are qualified or specific were presented in that fashion to make it clear that they formed no part of the subterranean dialogue in which Ammianus was engaged.

To conclude: Ammianus' imitation of the texts of Sallust, Livy and Tacitus is close and purposeful, and it testifies to his deep familiarity with the Latin literary tradition. We must dismiss the unfortunate idea that his hold on Latin came late and was precarious; and if we dislike the somewhat tempestuous and disorderly character of his prose, we should blame his taste and the taste of his times, not his education or the fact that he calls himself a Greek. The density of quotations and allusions, not only from the three great historians preceding him, but from Vergil and Statius, Aulus Gellius and, above all, Cicero, is an element of his style which testifies to his artistic aims. The problem with Ammianus, therefore, concerns not the authenticity of his knowledge (as if he were the excerptor he has been taken for) but the sanity and balance of his aesthetic and literary principles, and the indiscriminate resort to imitation which led him to fall into the trap against which Quintilian warned in 10.2, 13, 17, 27. Ammianus suffered from the illusion (not uncommon in the fourth century) that his history, in order to qualify as a literary production, needed to be a mosaic containing precious older material. Perhaps it was also his way of emphasizing continuity with the past and piety to the shades of its great literary and historical representatives.

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[45] It is thus significant that the one mention of Sallust in the preserved history (15.12.6) is connected not with an "allusion" but with his role as a historical source on Gaul.

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